ENTERTAINMENT

TRUTH BE TOLD

Actor Randeep Hooda employs candour effortlessly, and his Netflix series *CAT* only benefits from it

Randeep Hooda says it like it is. Just because everyone was jumping on the web series bandwagon never meant that he had to. "It's a longer format, it is a lot many more days," he says. "I was not looking [at it] to exploit my talent." Hooda's reluctance was finally broken when his friend and manager, Panchali Chakraverty, and director Balwinder Singh Janjua came to him with an offer he couldn't refuse—a show set in Punjab. "At the core, it had an emotional story, but it was also an espionage thriller. There's a lot happening in it," says Hooda. In the Netflix original *CAT* (releasing on December 9), the actor makes his OTT series debut as Gurnaam Singh, "a common man thrown into uncommon circumstances". The show will see him trying to save his younger brother.

This isn't the first time that Hooda, a Haryanvi by origin, is playing a Sikh character. In *Sarabjit* (2016), he played Sarabjit Singh, a man India claimed was only a farmer, while Pakistan convicted him of spying and terrorism. Hooda, at one point, had also spent considerable time prepping for a film on the Battle of Saragarhi, but it was sadly shelved. "I felt *CAT* would be a good way to imbibe the Sikh culture," says Hooda, after spending months shooting across 80 locations in Punjab.

Hooda, surprisingly, is the first to confess he is still not all too comfortable with the Punjabi dialect. "Nothing is easy. As soon as you start feeling it is, you should move on from it," he says. "I feel I have done that really well in my career." Though Hooda has been acting for 22 years, the actor admits that for 11 years, he did not visit "a movie set for a single day". He says, "That kind of pacing, voluntarily and involuntarily, and due to circumstances, of course, has really kept me from burning out. The time off rejuvenates you. At the end of the day, you play the strings of your own heart. Otherwise, you can lose your originality very easily." For Hooda, one way of staying authentic is taking on new challenges. In his next, a biopic of Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, he has taken on the additional duties of direction and writing, apart from acting. "I'm trying to enjoy the process but I'm not getting there yet. The workload is too much," he again says candidly. "Sometimes I feel it is not me, but the man himself who has chosen me."

Hooda lost 22 kilos to essay the part and he will end up spending nearly a year and a half shooting the project. "It is definitely stretching my imagination, and my physical and mental abilities to do three things in the same film," he says. That is why Hooda isn't certain if he will return for season two of *CAT*, often an adjudicator of a show's success. For now, he just can't get Savarkar out of his head. ■

Suhani Singh



RANDEEP HOODA, who earlier played a Sikh character in Sarabjit (2016), felt CAT would be a good way to imbibe the Sikh culture